ONE-OFF SHIURIM

Why Do We Whisper Barukh Shem?

Derech Hashem 4:4:7-8

Sefer: Derech Hashem by Rabbi Moshe Hayim Luzzatto (the Ramhal) **Section:** Part 4, Chapter 4, paragraphs 7-8 (beginning) **Shiur:** Part of Dayan Daniel Kada's Derech Hashem series at Tiferet Eyal, Thursday 17 February 2022

These notes are based on an automatic transcript of the recording.

Recap: three parts of the first verse

The Rabbi began by reviewing the previous class. The first verse of Shema, Shema Yisrael... Hashem Ehad, contains three things, each with its consequence:

1. Yihud Hashem, acknowledging God's oneness, through which evil is subdued.
2. Acknowledging God's Malkhut, His kingship, through which God becomes closer and more available, as it were.
3. Mesirut nefesh, giving up our lives, recognising that nothing exists apart from Hashem, through which light descends into the world.

Paragraph 7 now moves to the next line: Barukh Shem Kevod Malkhuto LeOlam VaEd.

What the words mean

The Rabbi translated carefully: "Blessed be the name of the glory of His kingdom for eternity." It is not God's name that is being blessed but the name of the glory of His kingdom.

Unlike the rest of Shema, which is made of verses from the Torah, this line is not a pasuk. It comes from a statement in the Gemara: when Yaakov was dying he gathered his twelve sons around him, and they said Shema Yisrael. He found nothing wrong in them; they were all continuing his path. Then he answered with these words. So why these words, and what do they have to do with Shema?

The Rabbi pointed out how seriously the halachah treats Barukh Shem. During the three paragraphs of Shema one may not initiate conversation, except out of fear of repercussions, and one may respond, for example to a parent. But during the first verse and Barukh Shem one may not interrupt at all, even where there is such fear. This shows that Barukh Shem is an intrinsic part of the whole thing.

The long chain toward unity

The Ramhal explains that all God's influences and illuminations reach the world in roundabout ways, yet they all originate in His unity. The world sees hundreds of things happening, and they all go back to One. Creatures are led through a long chain of events whose purpose is to

bring the world to its perfection, when it will be recognised that all authority belongs to Hakadosh Barukh Hu and that everything branches off His unity.

"We can't see it, we believe it." When Yihud Hashem is finally revealed, it will be understood how every link in the chain was leading there.

Since the purpose of the first verse is to recognise Yihud Hashem, the result of that recognition is that God rests His name upon us, a great cleaving to Him, and a constant leading toward perfection.

A participant asked whether free will can bring this perfection faster. The Rabbi agreed fully, citing the Gemara in Sanhedrin on the verse "BeItah Ahishenah": redemption can come at its appointed time, or it can be hastened. But, he added, in this world we cannot actually see Yihud Hashem on a global scale. On a personal level a person might understand why things happened in his own life, but how all the events of the whole world fit together can only be believed.

Who can say Barukh Shem?

Who actually knows that everything in this world happens for a purpose? We believe it; the angels know it. They are pure and holy, God's presence rests on them and they are in constant contact. Through them God's glory is constantly magnified, and so they can say this praise every day.

In our world God's glory is not magnified. He is not recognised as great, and while there is still evil we cannot see His glory increasing. So how can we say Barukh Shem?

Yaakov, on an individual level, merited it at the end of his life. All his children stood around him, all of them perfect, all to become the twelve tribes. They told him, in effect, that they could see this world as the glory of God. The Rabbi asked why the Ramhal calls Yaakov "the old one" here. His answer: Yaakov was at the end of his life, and it is when a person comes to die that he can really experience Yihud Hashem. The Rabbi also noted that the gematria of "Ehad" is 13: Yaakov with his twelve sons.

Because Yaakov said it, we may say it as well. But we say it only silently, because for us it is belief, not sight.

Yom Kippur

The exception is Yom Kippur, when Barukh Shem is said aloud. On Yom Kippur Israel are like the angels: we wear a tallit all day and stand as much as possible. Being in a state closer to the angels, we can perhaps recognise the glory a little more, and so we have the right to say it aloud.

This is the fourth point of Shema: after Yihud Hashem, Malkhut and mesirut nefesh, Barukh Shem, said silently because we say it after Yaakov and acknowledge a unity we do not see in our lifetime.

The three paragraphs of Shema

Paragraph 8 asks why we say these three paragraphs in particular. The Rabbi noted that people do not realise they come from three different places in the Torah and were put together to make Shema. The Ramhal says they complete the concept of the first verse, through three ideas:

1. Accepting the yoke of God's kingship, together with the love of God.
2. Accepting the yoke of the misvot.
3. Remembering the Exodus from Egypt.

The first paragraph, VeAhavta, strengthens our love for God in every circumstance, "with all your heart and all your might", unconditional and unflinching. It is not yet about misvot; it elaborates on the yoke of His sovereignty, and extends it to our children as well.

It also spreads this into every state of life, not only one part of the day: when you sit at home and when you go on your journey. Even the home is to be permeated with it, which is why it is written on the doorposts. What is in the mezuzah? Shema Yisrael, Yihud Hashem.

Looking at the mezuzah

This led the Rabbi to a practical point. There is no halachah of kissing the mezuzah. The first posek he knew of to mention it is the Kissur Shulhan Arukh of Rabbi Shlomo Ganzfried. The problem with touching it in passing is that "it doesn't mean anything." The point is to stop, look at the mezuzah and contemplate it for a moment. The same is true of sisit: the misvah is to look at them and remember the misvot, and kissing comes after. Kissing is a nice sign of affection, as we kiss a siddur, but it does not replace the main thing.

A participant recalled a teacher who advised not saying the LeShem Yihud before tefillin aloud, but reading through it in one's head, and found the effect remarkable. The Rabbi agreed that it is a powerful text about Yihud Hashem and suggested looking at it each morning, since it reminds us of the concept of tefillin.

The next class will cover the second and third paragraphs, the 248 and 365 words, and the blessings of Shema, finishing the chapter.

Summary

- Barukh Shem is not a verse from the Torah; it is what Yaakov answered when his twelve sons declared Shema Yisrael.
- All of history is a long chain leading toward the revelation of God's unity, which we believe but cannot yet see.
- The angels, who see God's glory, say Barukh Shem openly; we say it after Yaakov, but silently, except on Yom Kippur when we resemble the angels.
- The three paragraphs complete the first verse: love and kingship, the yoke of misvot, and remembering Egypt.
- The mezuzah and sisit are meant to be looked at and contemplated; kissing them is secondary.

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